

Building the Argument

Lesson 2 — Constructing a full Paper 3 essay

What you will know and be able to do

1

Write an introduction that states a clear position on the question's claim

2

Structure body paragraphs that each advance one part of your argument

3

Write a conclusion that reaches a genuine, reasoned judgement

4

Avoid the most common structural weaknesses examiners report

From deconstructing a question to answering it

Lesson 1 taught you to identify the command term and the claim inside a question. This lesson turns that analysis into an actual, complete essay — the structure that will hold every Paper 3 answer you write this year.

Four moves, in order

Introduction

State the claim, your position on it, and a brief preview of your argument's structure.

Body paragraphs

Each paragraph advances one distinct point, backed by specific evidence and, where relevant, historiography.

Counter-argument

Address the strongest case against your position before dismissing or qualifying it.

Conclusion

Restate your judgement clearly, as a genuine answer — not a summary of what you already wrote.

Take a position immediately

A strong introduction does not delay: within the first two or three sentences, state where you stand on the claim — fully agree, fully disagree, or a specific, qualified middle position (“largely, but not entirely”). Vague introductions that restate the question without committing to a view cost marks before the essay has properly begun.

One point, fully developed, per paragraph

Each paragraph should open with a clear topic sentence stating the point it will make, then support that point with specific facts, dates, and where useful a named historian's view — before explicitly linking back to the question's claim. A paragraph that drifts through several loosely related facts without a single clear point is description, not argument.

Address the strongest opposing case, not the weakest

Examiners specifically reward balance. Choose the single strongest piece of evidence against your position, present it fairly, and then explain precisely why your overall judgement still holds despite it. Dismissing a weak, easily beaten counter-argument does not demonstrate real balance.

A judgement, not a summary

“In conclusion, there were many causes of X” restates the obvious and earns little credit. A strong conclusion explicitly answers the question's claim — “Largely, then, this claim holds, though X was at least as significant as the factor named” — in language that could not apply to any other essay on any other topic.

The “list essay”

A common weak pattern: paragraph one describes cause A, paragraph two describes cause B, paragraph three describes cause C, with no paragraph ever comparing their relative importance. This is a list, not an argument. Somewhere — ideally throughout, but at minimum in your conclusion — you must actually weigh the causes against each other.

Plan a full essay skeleton

For the question 'Foreign intervention was the decisive factor in Congolese instability after 1960.' To what extent do you agree?, plan a full essay skeleton without writing full paragraphs.

- Write your introduction's opening two sentences in full, stating your position
- List each body paragraph's single main point in one sentence
- Identify your chosen counter-argument and how you will address it
- Write your conclusion's final judgement in one sentence

A strong opening, worked through

“Foreign intervention played a significant role in Congolese instability after 1960, but it was not decisive on its own: the collapse of colonial administrative structures and deep internal ethnic and political divisions created the conditions foreign powers were then able to exploit, rather than the reverse.” Notice: a clear position, stated immediately, already previewing the argument's shape.

Key terms from today

Thesis statement

The clear position on the claim stated in your introduction.

List essay

A weak structure describing causes in sequence without weighing them against each other.

Topic sentence

The opening sentence of a paragraph stating its single main point.

Counter-argument

The strongest case against your position, addressed fairly before you explain why your view still holds.

What to remember

A strong Paper 3 essay states its position immediately, develops one clear point per paragraph, addresses the strongest counter-argument fairly, and closes with a genuine judgement — not a summary. The “list essay”, describing causes without weighing them, is the most common structural weakness to avoid.

Lesson 3 — Using historiography effectively

Next lesson: how to bring named historians and real historical debates into your essay without turning it into a list of names — a skill examiners explicitly reward.